

CERTIFIED CIGAR SOMMELIER (CCS®)

MODULE 6 TEACHING MANUAL

STORAGE VS SMOKING RH

Status: Core Module – Mandatory

Applies to: CCS® Level I & ACS® Level II

Estimated Study Load: 3 Hours

TABLE OF CONTENTS

1. MODULE PURPOSE
2. LEARNING OUTCOMES
3. SECTION 1 - TWO DISTINCT OBJECTIVES
 - Why This Matters Professionally
 - 1.1 Long-Term Storage: Preservation
 - 1.2 Smoking Preparation: Performance
 - 1.3 Why One RH Cannot Satisfy Both
4. SECTION 2 - STORAGE RH: PROFESSIONAL GUIDELINES
 - 2.1 Typical Professional Storage Ranges
 - 2.2 Why Storage RH Is Higher
 - 2.3 Risks of Overly Dry Storage
5. SECTION 3 - SMOKING RH: PERFORMANCE TARGETS
 - 3.1 Smoking RH Definition
 - 3.2 Typical Peak Smoking RH by Family
 - 3.3 Why Smoking RH Must Be Precise
6. SECTION 4 - TRANSITION MANAGEMENT
 - 4.1 Why Transitions Matter More Than Numbers
 - 4.2 Transition Principles
 - 4.3 Typical Transition Methods
7. SECTION 5 - DRY-BOXING
 - 5.1 What Dry-Boxing Is

- 5.2 When Dry-Boxing Is Appropriate
 - 5.3 When Dry-Boxing Is Dangerous
 - 5.4 Dry-Boxing Timeframes
8. SECTION 6 - MULTI-ZONE SYSTEMS (LOUNGES & COLLECTORS)
- 6.1 Why Single-Humidor Systems Fail
 - 6.2 Professional Multi-Zone Design
 - 6.3 Operational Workflow Example
9. SECTION 7 - FAILURE MODES & DIAGNOSTICS
- Common Storage-Related Failures
10. SECTION 8 - APPLIED PROFESSIONAL SCENARIOS
- Scenario 1 - Lounge Storage Bias
 - Scenario 2 - Aggressive Dry-Boxing
11. SECTION 9 - EXAMINATION ALIGNMENT
- Common Examination Errors
12. SECTION 10 - CORE PROFESSIONAL PRINCIPLES
13. MODULE SUMMARY

MODULE PURPOSE

This module teaches candidates how to separate and manage two very different professional objectives:

1. Long-term cigar preservation
2. Short-term smoking performance

Many cigar failures occur because smokers incorrectly assume:

the ideal storage RH is automatically the ideal smoking RH.

In reality:

- storage systems prioritize protection and stability, while
- smoking preparation prioritizes combustion performance and flavour expression.

This module teaches candidates how to:

© 2026 International Cigar Sommelier Institute (ICSI®). All rights reserved. This training material is proprietary and confidential. Unauthorized reproduction, distribution, teaching, or commercial use, in whole or in part, is strictly prohibited without prior written permission from ICSI.

- manage both objectives correctly,
- transition cigars safely between environments,
- and design professional storage and staging systems.

By mastering this framework, the sommelier moves from:

“I store cigars.”

to:

“I prepare cigars for optimal performance.”

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this module, the candidate shall be able to:

1. Explain why storage RH differs from smoking RH
2. Define the goals of preservation vs performance
3. Design professional multi-zone storage systems
4. Use dry-boxing safely and correctly
5. Manage transitions between RH environments
6. Diagnose storage-related smoking failures
7. Implement professional lounge preparation workflows

SECTION 1

TWO DISTINCT OBJECTIVES

Why This Matters Professionally

Many lounges and collectors use:

- one humidor,
- one RH target,
- and one preparation method

for all cigars.

This often creates:

- muted flavours,
- unstable combustion,
- and inconsistent smoking experiences.

Professional cigar management separates:

- preservation,
from
- performance preparation.

These are related objectives, but they are not identical.

1.1 Long-Term Storage: Preservation

The purpose of long-term storage is to:

- protect wrapper integrity,
- prevent cracking and unravelling,
- slow chemical degradation,
- preserve aging potential,
- and reduce mould or pest risk.

Storage systems prioritize:

- safety,
- stability,
- and structural protection.

Storage is conservative by design.

1.2 Smoking Preparation: Performance

The purpose of smoking preparation is to:

- optimize combustion,
- maximize flavour expression,
- improve burn stability,
- and align flavour timing.

Unlike storage, smoking preparation focuses on:

© 2026 International Cigar Sommelier Institute (ICSI®). All rights reserved. This training material is proprietary and confidential. Unauthorized reproduction, distribution, teaching, or commercial use, in whole or in part, is strictly prohibited without prior written permission from ICSI.

immediate functional performance.

The cigar only needs to remain in this state:

- long enough to smoke correctly.

1.3 Why One RH Cannot Satisfy Both

An RH level ideal for storage is often:

- too humid for peak smoking performance,
- too protective,
- and too combustion-buffered.

This may:

- suppress aromatics,
- mute sweetness,
- and reduce flavour clarity.

By contrast, an RH ideal for smoking may:

- expose wrappers to stress over long periods,
- increase cracking risk,
- and accelerate aging damage.

Professional cigar management therefore separates:

- storage RH,
from
- smoking RH.

SECTION 2

STORAGE RH: PROFESSIONAL GUIDELINES

2.1 Typical Professional Storage Ranges

Cigar Family	Typical Storage RH
Aromatic / Delicate	61–62%

Cigar Family	Typical Storage RH
---------------------	---------------------------

Balanced Boutique	63–64%
-------------------	--------

Power / Ligero-Heavy	65–66%
----------------------	--------

These are:

- preservation-oriented ranges, not
- smoking targets.

2.2 Why Storage RH Is Higher

Higher storage RH helps:

- protect wrappers,
- slow moisture loss,
- reduce environmental fluctuation,
- and provide structural safety margins.

Storage systems prioritize:

- stability over flavour precision.

This is intentional.

2.3 Risks of Overly Dry Storage

Excessively dry long-term storage may cause:

- wrapper cracking,
- cap failure,
- accelerated aging,
- structural fragility,
- and irreversible tobacco damage.

A professional sommelier should never sacrifice:

- cigar preservation for
- short-term convenience.

SECTION 3

SMOKING RH: PERFORMANCE TARGETS

3.1 Smoking RH Definition

Smoking RH refers to:

the leaf-level moisture condition of the cigar at the moment of ignition.

It is not:

- an ambient air reading,
- or a humidor display number.

This distinction is extremely important professionally.

3.2 Typical Peak Smoking RH by Family

RH Family	Typical Peak Smoking RH
-----------	-------------------------

Family A - Aromatic	59–61%
---------------------	--------

Family B - Balanced	61–62%
---------------------	--------

Family C - Power	63–65%
------------------	--------

These are:

- combustion-performance targets, not
 - storage recommendations.
-

3.3 Why Smoking RH Must Be Precise

During smoking:

- combustion begins immediately,
- flavour windows are narrow,
- and there is no moisture buffer.

Even small RH deviations may instantly affect:

- sweetness,
- combustion speed,
- smoke texture,
- and aroma clarity.

Professional preparation therefore requires precision.

SECTION 4

TRANSITION MANAGEMENT

4.1 Why Transitions Matter More Than Numbers

Many cigar failures are caused not by:

- incorrect storage RH,

but by:

- poor transition management.

Rapid RH changes can create:

- moisture gradients,
- cap-foot imbalance,
- and wrapper/core mismatch.

A perfectly stored cigar can still perform poorly if transitions are rushed.

4.2 Core Transition Principles

Principle 1

Slow changes are safer than rapid changes.

Principle 2

The direction of RH movement matters.

Principle 3

Dense cigars require longer equilibration.

Principle 4

Leaf-level diagnostics confirm readiness better than assumptions.

4.3 Typical Transition Methods

Professional transition methods include:

- resting,
- staging humidors,
- controlled dry-boxing,
- and controlled ambient exposure.

Each method has:

- benefits,
- limitations,
- and risks.

Professional preparation requires deliberate process control.

SECTION 5

DRY-BOXING

5.1 What Dry-Boxing Is

Dry-boxing is:

controlled exposure to lower RH air in order to move a cigar into its optimal smoking window.

Dry-boxing is not:

- rapid dehydration,
- or uncontrolled drying.

Used correctly, it is a precision preparation tool.

5.2 When Dry-Boxing Is Appropriate

Dry-boxing may be useful for:

- short-term smoking preparation,

- reducing mild over-humidification,
 - and fine-tuning performance before service.
-

5.3 When Dry-Boxing Becomes Dangerous

Dry-boxing becomes risky when used:

- on already dry cigars,
- for excessive durations,
- on delicate wrappers,
- or in hot environments.

Improper dry-boxing may create:

- wrapper cracking,
 - uneven equalization,
 - and combustion instability.
-

5.4 Typical Dry-Boxing Timeframes

RH Reduction Typical Time

-1%	12–48 hours
-2%	2–5 days
-3%	5–10 days

These are approximate guidelines only.

Always confirm readiness using:

- cap-foot diagnostics,
 - and smoking evaluation.
-

SECTION 6

MULTI-ZONE SYSTEMS (LOUNGES & COLLECTORS)

6.1 Why Single-Humidor Systems Fail

© 2026 International Cigar Sommelier Institute (ICSI®). All rights reserved. This training material is proprietary and confidential. Unauthorized reproduction, distribution, teaching, or commercial use, in whole or in part, is strictly prohibited without prior written permission from ICSI.

A single RH environment cannot optimally serve:

- every blend,
- every wrapper style,
- every density level,
- and every smoking target.

Single-zone systems often:

- over-humidify delicate cigars,
- underperform powerful blends,
- and create inconsistent customer experiences.

6.2 Professional Multi-Zone Design

Professional systems commonly include:

Primary Storage

- preservation-focused,
- stability-first,
- low disturbance.

Staging Humidor

- preparation-focused,
- controlled transitions,
- RH fine-tuning.

Service-Ready Stock

- equalized,
- performance-optimized,
- ready for immediate smoking.

Zones may differ by:

- RH,
- airflow,
- temperature,

- and access frequency.

6.3 Example Professional Workflow

Step 1

Receive shipment and allow stabilization.

Step 2

Classify cigars by RH Family.

Step 3

Stage toward target smoking RH.

Step 4

Confirm equalization using diagnostics.

Step 5

Serve confidently.

SECTION 7

FAILURE MODES & DIAGNOSTICS

Common Storage-Related Failures

Symptom	Likely Cause
Flat flavour	Over-humidified wrapper
Harshness	Under-humidified core
Uneven burn	Poor transition management
Inconsistent batches	Uncontrolled staging

Professional Perspective

Most storage failures are:

- process failures,
not

- cigar failures.

Consistency comes from:

- disciplined workflows,
- controlled transitions,
- and proper staging systems.

SECTION 8

APPLIED PROFESSIONAL SCENARIOS

Scenario 1 - Lounge Stores Everything at 70%

Professional Diagnosis

- Storage bias,
- suppressed aromatics,
- delayed flavour release,
- combustion inefficiency.

Recommended Correction

- Introduce staging zones,
- reduce service RH,
- educate staff on performance preparation.

Scenario 2 - Aggressive Dry-Boxing

Professional Diagnosis

- Excessive moisture removal,
- wrapper damage risk,
- unequalized combustion behaviour.

Recommended Correction

- Limit dry-boxing to preparation use,
- restore proper storage RH,

- prioritize gradual transitions.
-

SECTION 9

EXAMINATION ALIGNMENT

Candidates must be able to:

- explain why storage RH differs from smoking RH,
 - design proper transition strategies,
 - justify dry-boxing decisions,
 - and diagnose storage-related failures.
-

Common Examination Errors

Candidates often:

- treat dry-boxing as a default procedure,
- ignore equilibration time,
- chase RH numbers without diagnostics,
- or confuse preservation goals with smoking goals.

Professional analysis must remain:

- process-based,
 - evidence-driven,
 - and combustion-focused.
-

SECTION 10

CORE PROFESSIONAL PRINCIPLES

Candidates should be able to defend the following statements:

1. Storage protects cigars; smoking reveals them.
2. One RH cannot optimize both preservation and performance.
3. Transitions influence smoking outcomes more than static RH numbers.
4. Dry-boxing is a precision tool, not a routine habit.

5. Consistent cigar experiences require process discipline.

MODULE SUMMARY

This module establishes that:

- storage and smoking preparation are different objectives,
- professional systems separate preservation from performance,
- transitions are the critical control point,
- and consistent excellence requires intentional workflow design.

With this framework mastered, the sommelier moves from:

“I keep cigars well.”

to:

“I prepare cigars to perform at their peak.”

